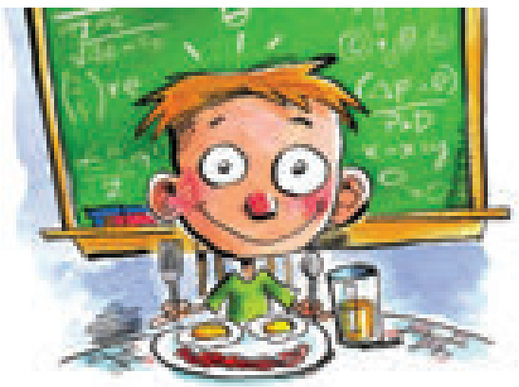
- Kichdi, buttermilk, coriander chutney
- Adai with drumstick leaves and coconut chutney

## 3.4 Breakfast - the most important meal of the Day

A nutritious breakfast is a central feature of a child's diet that supports healthy growth and development. Breakfast is the first meal of the day. A healthy breakfast refuels the body and replenishes the blood sugar (glucose), giving the energy necessary to start a new day. It is proven that breakfast is good for both physical and mental health. Nutrients missed from a skipped breakfast won't be "made up" at lunch and dinner but will be left out completely that day.



Eating breakfast is important for all ages, especially for children and adolescents. It is observed that children who eat breakfast are more likely to have better concentration, problem-solving skills and eye-hand coordination. They may also be more alert and attentive in class. Eating breakfast every day will help to maintain concentration in class.

A good breakfast should be able to provide one third of the total daily energy requirement. A typical breakfast includes a cereal (for example, rice, wheat and ragi), protein-rich food such as egg, a glass of milk and vitamin C rich fruit e.g. orange, and papaya

### 3.4.1 Advantages of a healthy breakfast

Children who eat a healthy breakfast are more likely to:

- **Have better concentration and be more productive throughout the morning :** This may be due to replenishing glucose, the brain's main energy source.
- **Control their weight:** Eating breakfast may reduce hunger later in the day and it may help eaters to avoid junk foods at later meals.
- **Have more strength and endurance:** People who eat breakfast have higher energy levels, and may engage in more physical activity than many people who don't eat breakfast.




An overnight and morning fast among school children can have deleterious effects on memory and attention. Research shows that skipping breakfast can have adverse effects on both energy levels and cognition of school children.

**THINK BEFORE YOU SKIP YOUR BREAKFAST**

### 3.4.2 Tips for a healthy breakfast

A healthy breakfast should consist of a variety of foods. To make a healthy breakfast each day, choose one item from at least three of the following four food groups:

- **Fruits and vegetables:** Consider fresh, whole fruits and vegetables, or 100 percent fruit juice without added sugar.
- **Grains:** Choose whole-grain cereals, and not refined flour like maida.
- **Dairy :** Consider skim milk, low-fat yogurt or low-fat cheeses, such as cottage and natural cheeses.



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